

news feed

DIGIT JULY 2004

hypothesis

DualDisc

■ What is it?

The latest format of Audio-DVDs, recently approved by the DVD Forum. It will have DVD audio on one side and CD audio on the other.

■ How does it work?

The disk will be about 1.5 mm thick. A typical DualDisc would feature a single-sided DVD and a thinner CD layer on the flip side. Right now, a DualDisc is 1.48 mm thick. And the end result? A DVD with 5.1 surround sound and other DVD features for high-end music. The CD side will have standard music sampled at 44.1 KHz for CD players.

■ What does it do?

DualDiscs will give music companies promoting DVD audio a shot in the arm. Meanwhile, there will be the benefit of the flexibility of the CD format. We are talking about a DVD that becomes widely compatible because it packs in a CD. A DVD by itself is not as compatible as a CD is. Music companies will sell this product as something that has both CD and DVD, and will expect substantial demand for DualDiscs. In the long run, producers will save quite a bit, since they won't have to ship a DVD along with a CD in a package. DualDiscs will come to the rescue of the DVD-Audio format. However, there are limitations. The CD side will have only 60 minutes of audio, and the DVD side, obviously, cannot be double-layered.

Of cell phones, slaps and airplanes

It's typical, you're in a movie, it's an intense scene, you're hanging onto the dialogue for dear life, and off goes a cell phone close by—arrrgh! Certain situations require a little etiquette, but some people take matters a little too far.

Consider the young woman who was banned from flying Vietnam Airways because she attacked a stewardess who asked her to stop talking on her cell phone. Not only did she refuse to stop her conversation, she also slapped the flight attendant and threw water in her face! So can we

expect laws that prevent this sort of behaviour in India, or do we get slapped every time we object to those pesky nuisances? Only time will tell. Write in and tell us what you think about such situations!



Cops on e-beat

Watch out perverts, cops are patrolling Internet chat rooms as well now! In order to crack down on growing paedophile rings, police from Britain, the US, Canada and Australia are forming a global taskforce. Web sites with child pornography will have their finances confiscated, and buyers of the disgusting material will have their credit cards frozen. Of course, with laws being so varied around the globe, the cops have to identify themselves.

They'll keep an eye on chat rooms, and a badge saying 'Virtual Global Task Force' will



identify them to the public. Will this measure stop the paedophiles from looking for prey online? We certainly hope so, at least someone's doing something, right?

Fine that spam!

The land of really clean roads may now become the land of really clean e-mail boxes! If the Singapore government has its way, that is. As with littering the roads, the government will impose a fine on spammers that litter mailboxes. Fed up of blocking spammers, Singapore has decided to fine them between 10 cents and one Singapore dollar (approximately Rs 3 to Rs 26) per spam e-mail.

Will this deter spammers from setting up shop in Singapore? We hope so, provided you can track these spammers! Let's wait till January 2005, when this Act comes into force, and see.

Cough, then sing

In June 2003, one billion music files were shared across the world! This year, the number is 70 per cent lower. Why? The International Federation of the Phonographic Industry (IFPI) is grinning from ear to ear, citing its tougher stance on illegal file sharing and copyright issues as the reason for this decline.

Interestingly, there are now over 100 Web sites that you can buy music (read: legal downloads) from. The IFPI plans on enforcing the rules even more strenuously in the future—so be prepared to see more lawsuits in the news. The message is simple: If you want to sing along to your favourite tunes, cough up the dough first!